



terms of classic Al Qaeda tactics, there were the simultaneous attacks on multiple targets (including Americans, British and Israelis) but no use of massive bombs. Critically, the spectacular suicide of the attackers—an integral part of all Al Qaeda plots hitherto—was not apparently part of the plan. We have seen hostage taking before—in Moscow and Chechnya—and fidayeen-style guns and grenades raids—in Kashmir, Saudi Arabia and Afghanistan—but never everything at the same time. The strike on Mumbai was a strike not just at the commercial heart but at a city considered by Islamic militants the Hindu heart of India. This—and the mix of tactics and mixed competence of the attackers—may suggest a combined operation by some Al Qaeda input, a LeT element and all combined with, at least, some local help.

Since being struck by the scourge of terrorism, the UK and the US have taken different paths, though both have poured massive resources into their intelligence services. The US created the department for homeland security to get all their multitudinous agencies working together. The UK instead implemented a series of reforms aimed at bettering cooperation and intelligence among its services. A key element has been getting informa-

Terrorism in the UK is seen as a police matter—with all the short-term drawbacks and long-term advantages that it brings. A vast amount of research has also been done on terrorist networks and particularly what makes individuals become militants and killers. This research, by bureaucrats, intelligence analysts and sponsored academics, draws on cutting-edge sociology, criminology and psychology. It is not always transferable from nation to nation as situations differ but the range of agencies conducting such work—from the Australians to Saudi Arabians—means that there is a wealth of data available to help and inform policy-making.

Overseas experts judge the Indian counter-terrorism effort harshly. According to Nigel Inkster, a former deputy director of MI6, now at the Royal United Services Institute in London, it has been hobbled by tensions between the states and the Central Government, a lack of coherent anti-terrorist legislation and chronic long-term underfunding of police and security agencies. "They are badly trained, poorly equipped, with no concept of capturing or applying best practice, forensic investigation or command and control," says Inkster adding that even-handed treatment of all extrem-

WITH AFGHANISTAN AT A CRITICAL CROSSROADS, THE US MAY NOT WANT TO FURTHER DESTABILISE PAKISTAN.

tion to people who can act on it. In terms of pure resources, there has been massive expansion too. Britain's MI5 domestic agency has seen its staff grow from 2,000 in 2004 to 3,000 this year with further expansion to nearly 4,000 set for the next.

This has allowed regional MI5 offices to be set up to work alongside local police. Local sources within the Muslim community have been assiduously cultivated—many tips now come from people worried about extremists influencing their children or communities. One key difference between the US and the British approach has been the resolute determination of the latter—despite the vast range of increased legal powers for holding prisoners without charge—to remain within a strictly legal framework.

ism in India, of whatever origin, was crucial in designing an effective strategic response.

If India is bearing the brunt of a movement fuelled by events in the Middle East, there is a limited amount that she can do. If the killers were 'home-grown' there is clearly much more. There is a pattern of states blaming 'external forces' for problems with Islamic militancy rather than face up to their own internal problems. What all experts agree on is that any counter-terrorist strategy has to be based on an honest appraisal of the situations and limitations. It remains to be seen whether that is possible.

Burke is the chief foreign correspondent of The Observer and author of Al Qaeda: The True Story of Radical Islam.

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